‘Best in Europe’ to ‘bang average’?

An outlet’s headline claim, tested against EEA data

THE CLAIM

> ***“Maltese waters have suffered a downgrade from best in Europe to bang average.”***

Business Now, 17 Aug 2026

Malta’s counts are the EEA’s; its rank fell from third to eleventh of 22 EU coastal states.

‘Best’ is a loose word for third place; the fall is in the share rated excellent, not in safety.

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

Right on the change; ‘best’ was third.

SUPPORTED | **LARGELY SUPPORTED** | NOT SUBSTANTIATED | MISLEADING | CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

86 → 77

Sites rated excellent, 2016 → 2025

Of 87 Maltese bathing waters: 98.9% down to 88.5% (EEA).

3rd → 11th

Rank among 22 EU coastal states

Behind Slovenia (16 sites) and Cyprus in 2016; ten states ahead in 2025.

88.5%

Malta in 2025

Against 88.3% pooled across EU coastal waters: ‘average’ fits.

0 poor

Maltese sites rated poor

None in 2016 or 2025; every site met the minimum standard.

Not tested

Week-13 figure (56 of 87)

From the article only; a weekly count is not a season class.

FAIR TO SAY

The change is real and the article’s counts are exact. ‘Downgrade’ concerns the top class, not unsafe water.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

- ☐ Say ‘third’ or ‘top three’ rather than ‘best’.
- ☐ Compare season classes with season classes.
- ☐ Publish the weekly Directorate files with a method note.
- ☐ Report the share and the minimum-standard pass rate together.